

Letter Fifty-Two

THE PETRINE MINISTRY OF THE
ROMAN PONTIFF IN LIGHT OF THE CHURCH
AS THE ICON OF THE HOLY TRINITY

Dear Euthymios,

You have provided quotations from a Greek Orthodox theologian, Fr. George Dragas, which deal with Eastern Orthodox ecclesiology. They are very much to the point, especially when he writes:

The nature of the Church is to be understood as the Church of the Triune God. The Holy Trinity is the ultimate basis and source of the Church's existence and, as such, the Church is in the image and likeness of God. This being in the image of the Blessed Trinity constitutes the mode of the Church's existence which, in fact, reveals her nature. Being in God, the Church reflects on earth God's unity in Trinity. . . . The unity of the three divine persons in life and being is, therefore, the prototype of the unity of the Church's persons in life and in being. As Christ Himself says in His prayer for the Church, "Even as thou, O Father, are in me and me in thee, so they may be one in us, that the world may believe that thou hast sent me" (John 17:21). . . . The Church is an *eikon* [icon] of the Holy Trinity, a participation in the

grace of God. . . . How does the Church become an *eikon* of the Holy Trinity? The answer in its fullest form is contained in the phrase "in and through Christ." Christ has established the bond between the image of the Triune God, and that which is made after the image, namely, the Church, mankind. . . . We must say that the Church is the Church of the Triune God as the Church of Christ. The link between the Holy Trinity and Christology, that is, between theology and economy, demands a similar link in ecclesiology. The Church is in the image of the Triune God, and participates in the grace of the Trinity inasmuch as she is in Christ and partakes of His grace. . . . Christ is the head of the Church and she is His body. It is from this Christological angle that we better understand the multiplicity in unity which exists in the Church. . . . The Triadological¹ and Christological dimensions cannot be divorced in Orthodox ecclesiology because the Church is the Church of the Holy Trinity insofar as she is the Church of Christ, and vice versa.²

Bishop Maximos Aghiorgoussis, the former Greek Orthodox Metropolitan of Pittsburgh, developed further the theme of Church as icon of the Holy Trinity, attracting particular attention to the place of hierarchy and structure in the Church:

The Church as *ekklesia* (*qahal* [Hebrew]) is a corporate reality, a unity of persons called together by God which reflects the kind of society that the Holy Trinity is. For the Church is created after the image of the Holy Trinity, in whose life it participates.

¹ Triadology is the study of the Holy Trinity, which is intimately related to Christology, the study of Jesus Christ, including His relationship with His Mystical Body, the Church.

² Fr. George Dragas, "Orthodox Ecclesiology in Outline," *The Greek Orthodox Theological Review* 26, no. 3 (1981): 185–192.

As there is hierarchy in the Holy Trinity, there is hierarchy and structure in the Church. As there is equality of persons in the Holy Trinity, there is equality of persons and personal destinies in the life of the Church. The Church is only one communion of saints, in which all saints, all Christians, are called to respond to the common call to holiness. At the same time, hierarchy and structure in the Church is part of the being of the Church as instituted by Christ. The people of God is not left without leaders: the body of Christ is not an amorphous accumulation of cells, but an organic body, with distinct parts having distinct functions. The holy construction, the holy temple of God, is not without foundations, columns, and cornerstones, and having the apostles' successors as pillars which hold the temple standing and united.³

The ecclesiological implications of the *Filioque* have been noted by a number of other Eastern Orthodox theologians, who candidly acknowledge that, long before the formal schism with Rome (i.e., by the sixth century), the doctrine of the *Filioque* was part of the *fidei symbolum* ("symbol of the faith" or "faith creed").⁴ One such author, writing in *St. Vladimir's Theological Review*, noted that the Catholic teaching on the procession of the Holy Spirit logically resulted in an emphasis on "the Christological or hierarchical aspect of the Church . . . and the importance of the Church's ministry in terms of 'authority,' culminating in the well-known dogma of the Pope's infallibility in 1870."⁵ The same author went

³ Bishop Maximos Aghiorgoussis, "The Church as a Presupposition for the Proclamation of the Gospel," *The Greek Orthodox Theological Review* 25, no. 4 (1980): 313.

⁴ The term is borrowed from the ancient world, in which a *symbolon* was a material object that symbolized an agreement or other important reality. And so early Christians appropriated it for their creeds, including serving as a way in which they could discreetly identify themselves to each other—in a hostile culture—through the furtive showing of a token or symbol. See "Apostles' Creed" in *The Catholic Encyclopedia* at newadvent.org.

⁵ J. van Rossum, "Reflections on Byzantine Ecclesiology: Nicetas Stethatos' *On the Hierarchy*," *St. Vladimir's Theological Quarterly* 25, no. 2 (1981), 75–83.

on to claim mistakenly that, in the Catholic vision of the Trinity, “the ‘first principle of the Godhead’ is the divine essence and not the person of the Father”; “the basis of the Church’s existence is no longer the ‘life-creating Trinity’”; and “the doctrine of the *Filioque* is . . . the symbol of a distorted ecclesiology.”⁶

What constitutes a “distorted ecclesiology” will be further treated, but allow me, Euthymios, to quote an important Franciscan theologian of the thirteenth century, who may be said to have replied to such extreme allegations in observing:

The greatest glory of the Son of God . . . [is] the truth which asserts that He [together with the Father] is the principle of the Holy Spirit. This is greater than the glory which asserts that He is the origin of all created things. . . . The most noble act of the Holy Spirit . . . is that from the Son He, the Holy Spirit, eternally receives His divine being. For the greatest honor and glory of the Son consists in this: that He is the origin of the Holy Spirit. The infinite liberality of the Almighty Father is also proclaimed in this truth, because He communicates to the Son the productive power not only in time but also from eternity. And so, let us hope that in confessing this, they [the Byzantine Greek Orthodox] will honor not only the Son but will glorify [with us] the whole Blessed Trinity.⁷

Catholic theologians have written similarly, Euthymios, concerning the Church as the icon of the Holy Trinity and the Church as the fullness, the prolongation, and the mystical continuation of Christ’s sacred humanity in time. They, too, have noted that the unity of the Church mirrors the unity of the three Persons of

⁶ J. van Rossum, “Reflections on Byzantine Ecclesiology: Nicetas Stethatos’ *On the Hierarchy*,” 75–83.

⁷ Fr. Matthew of Aquasparta, *Tract on the Procession of the Holy Spirit*, no. 42. For further excerpts from this *Tract*, and for full citation information, see Appendix II of this book.

the Blessed Trinity. They are in agreement that ecclesiology and Christology are inseparable from Triadology, the study of the Holy Trinity. They do not agree, however, that the “interpenetration of the Trinitarian and Christological dimensions” negates the Petrine primacy of universal jurisdiction in the Church as willed by Christ, who, as head of the Church, is minister of the unity of His ecclesial body. Rather, as will be seen, the Church as the icon of the Holy Trinity demands an indivisible center of unity in the apostolic episcopate as willed by Christ, and which alone can make intelligible the patristic concept of the hierarchical Church as an “undivided Church,” and as a communion of local churches constituting a “unity in plurality.”

The rich theology of Vatican II has presented a profound view of the Church as the icon of the Holy Trinity. The Church comes from the Trinity, is structured in the image of the Trinity, and journeys toward the Trinity. The Church is a “mystery of communion,” in which the Lord Jesus, through the Holy Spirit whom He poured forth at Pentecost, “called and gathered together the people of the New Covenant . . . into a unity of faith, hope, and charity.”⁸ In the famous words of the martyr St. Cyprian of Carthage, the Church is “a people made one with the unity of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.”⁹ Accordingly, in Vatican II’s *Decree on Ecumenism*, we read:

This is the sacred mystery of the unity of the Church, in Christ and through Christ, with the Holy Spirit energizing its various functions. The highest exemplar and source of this mystery is the unity, in the Trinity of Persons, of one God, the Father and the Son in the Holy Spirit.¹⁰

⁸ Second Vatican Council, Decree on Ecumenism *Unitatis Redintegratio* (November 21, 1964), no. 2.

⁹ St. Cyprian of Carthage, *De Oratione Dominicae (On the Lord's Prayer)* ch. 23, trans. Robert Ernest Wallis, Ante-Nicene Fathers, vol. 5, ed. Alexander Roberts, James Donaldson, and A. Cleveland Coxe (Buffalo, NY: Christian Literature, 1886), rev. and ed. Kevin Knight, New Advent, <http://www.newadvent.org/fathers/050704.htm>.

¹⁰ Second Vatican Council, *Unitatis Redintegratio*, no. 2.

Vatican II's *Decree on the Missionary Activity of the Church* similarly teaches:

The pilgrim Church is missionary by her very nature, since it is from the mission of the Son and the mission of the Holy Spirit that she draws her origin, in accordance with the decree of God the Father.

This decree, however, flows from the "fount-like love" or charity of God the Father who, being the "principle without principle" from whom the Son is begotten and Holy Spirit proceeds through the Son, freely creating us on account of His surpassing and merciful kindness and . . . [brings] about at one and the same time His own glory and our happiness. . . . [I]t pleased God to call men to share His life, not just singly, apart from any mutual bond, but rather to mold them into a people in which His sons, once scattered abroad, might be gathered together (cf. John 11:52).¹¹

In chapter three of my book *Ending the Byzantine Greek Schism*, Euthymios, I had observed how the Christological nature of the Church was precisely reflected in the relationship between the papacy and the episcopacy. Christ Himself had indeed constructed His Church upon all the apostles as its "pillars," but structured it so that all the apostolic foundations themselves rested on the Rock-foundation of Peter. I also noted how the hierarchical structure of the Church "splendidly mirrors the very hierarchy of Persons in the Triune God." In a profound intuition, St. Thomas Aquinas had discerned that

the error, however, of those who say that the Vicar of Christ, the Pontiff of the Roman Church, does not have a primacy over the universal Church is similar to the error

¹¹ Second Vatican Council, *Ad Gentes*, no. 2.

of those who say that the Holy Spirit does not proceed from the Son. For Christ Himself, the Son of God, consecrates and marks her as His own with the Holy Spirit, as it were with His own character and seal. . . . And in like manner the Vicar of Christ, by his primacy and his foresight as a faithful servant, keeps the Church universal subject to Christ, . . . [holding] the fullness of power over the whole Church of Christ.¹²

I recommend, Euthymios, a careful reading of both chapter three and chapter five in *Ending the Byzantine Greek Schism*, because I explain how there is indeed an ontological relationship between the Trinitarian procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and (or through) the Son, and the doctrine of the Petrine ministry of the Roman Pontiff in Christ's one and only visible Church. The word "ontological" is appropriate in the sense of that which pertains to the real [i.e., the order of being or existence]. Because the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Son as well as from the Father, the mission of the Holy Spirit in the life of the Church is always in harmony with Christ, the head of the Church, who governs His Bride through His Vicar, the Successor of Peter, and the bishops in communion with him. The authority of the Pope is a real one, involving not merely a priority in hierarchical rank but an authoritative jurisdiction over the entire Church, East and West. It is ontological in nature, not merely analogical. On the other hand, the Pope, as a human ruler subject to all the frailties and weaknesses of human nature, can only be properly understood in an analogical manner in relation to the invisible ruler of the Church, Christ the God-man. However, the point that cannot be stressed sufficiently is that the source of the Pope's teaching authority in the Church is Christ and the Holy Spirit. His authority involving a universal jurisdiction over all the faithful, including bishops, is real and grounded in the order of being (i.e.,

¹² Aquinas, *Contra Errores Graecorum*, ch. 32.

it is ontological). “Ontological” does not mean that it must be so by necessity, but, as a free gift of God, it has been made part of the *ordo salutis* (order/economy of salvation), specifically established by Christ, founder of the Church.

As I noted in *Ending the Byzantine Greek Schism*, St. Thomas Aquinas, and Catholic theologians in general, discerned that the mission of the Holy Spirit to serve as the uncreated soul of the Church—filling it with all His supernatural gifts, charisms, and offices—presupposed His eternal procession from the Father and (or through) the Son as from one and the same principle. This temporal mission of the Holy Spirit to the Church and the world mirrors, in time, His eternal relation to the Father and the Word. Receiving the divine essence or substance from the Father and the Son, the Holy Spirit clearly must proceed from both. In the thought of the Fathers, there was no question that the Holy Spirit proceeded from the Father *principaliter* (i.e., “chiefly”) as St. Augustine taught, and thereby was united to the Father. But if the Holy Spirit did not also draw His origin from the Son (i.e., receive His existence from Him), the Holy Spirit would not be united to the Son, and therefore the Son could not “send” Him in His temporal mission as the uncreated soul of the Church.¹³

It is by His procession, which is one of love from the Father and the Son, that the Holy Spirit is constituted the unity of both. As St. Augustine taught, “The Holy Spirit is possessed in common by the Father and by the Son, because He is the one Spirit of both.”¹⁴ The Father and the Son are and ever remain indivisibly one in the Holy Spirit. If the Holy Spirit did not proceed from the Son—or through the Son, as the Greek Fathers generally held—to receive

¹³ In addition, the Spirit not processing from *also*—or *through*—the Son would, in addition, necessarily render the Son less than co-equal with the Father, because He would be totally unassociated or disconnected with the origin and procession of the Spirit. This disconnection would necessarily introduce disunity between the Divine Persons, an unthinkable reality for the Triune Godhead.

¹⁴ St. Augustine, Sermon 71, *The Works of Saint Augustine: A Translation for the 21st Century, Part III: Sermons, Vol. III: Sermons 51–94*, trans. Fr. Edmund Hill, O.P., ed. Fr. John E. Rotelle, OSA (Brooklyn, NY: New City Press, 1991), 267.

the substance of the Father, He would be separated from the Son. The perfect indivisible unity of the Blessed Trinity would thus be destroyed, since the Holy Spirit would be divided from the oneness in substance of the Father and the Son. But there cannot be such division in the divine nature or essence of God. An absolute and formal denial of the procession of the Holy Spirit from the Father and the Son, as continues to be found among neo-Photian and neo-Palamite theologians, introduces schism into the heart of the Blessed Trinity, and consequently into the Church itself which, as we have seen, must mirror in its hierarchy and constitutional structure the indivisible unity of the Trinity.¹⁵ The indivisible unity of Christ's visible Church is declared by Christ Himself, when He prayed that, in addition to the internal unity of the Church as a spiritual and mystical organism, its visible unity must also mirror the oneness of the Father and the Son in the divine nature:

Yet not for these only do I pray [the Twelve Apostles], but for those also who through their word are to believe in me, that they may all be one in us, as thou, Father, in me, and I in thee, that they may also be one in us, that the world may believe that thou has sent me. And the glory that thou hast given me, I have given to them, that they may be one, even as we are one: I in them and thou in me; that they may be perfected in unity, and that the world may know that thou has sent me, and that thou hast loved them even as thou hast loved me. (John 17:20–23)

Regarding the Trinitarian model for the Church, our Orthodox brethren interestingly have little or nothing to say about the perichoresis of the Divine Persons in each other (i.e., the reciprocal presence and interpenetration or coinherence of the three Persons of the Blessed Trinity), a doctrine much emphasized by

¹⁵ See footnotes 19 and 2—and my related analysis in the text—regarding the related (and consequent) divine inequality between the Father and the Son.

St. Gregory Nazianzus and St. John Damascene. This was a key element in Our Lord's discourse: "That they may all be one, even as thou, Father, in me, and I in thee; that they also may be one in us, that the world may believe that thou hast sent me" (John 17:21). An understanding of this doctrine throws light not only on the necessity of the Holy Spirit proceeding from the Son, but also on the Peter-centered nature of the Church's hierarchical constitution. Whereas the multiplicity of Persons in the Trinity is alleged by Orthodox theologians to justify the existence of their assemblage of autocephalous churches, which lack visible unity under one supreme head, the doctrine of perichoresis rather justifies the presence, effectively and jurisdictionally, of him—the Successor of Peter—who represents the Father in each and every local Church, so that the visible unity of the Church may be perfect with that perfection which belongs to the Divine Trinity. The visible communion of the Church mirrors, in fact, the mysterious communion and perichoresis among the three Persons in the Trinity.

In the very important *Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on Some Aspects of the Church Understood as Communion*, issued by the Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith in 1992, we find, Euthymios, an explanation of the true nature of *communio* [communion] in the Church, with particular reference to the primacy of headship exercised by the Roman Pontiff in the communion of churches that make up the Catholic Church:

But for each particular church to be fully Church, that is, the particular presence of the universal Church with all its essential elements, and hence constituted *after the model of the universal Church*, there must be present in it, as a proper element, the supreme authority of the Church: the Episcopal College "*together with their head, the Supreme Pontiff, and never apart from him.*" The primacy of the Bishop of Rome and the Episcopal College are proper elements of the universal Church that are "*not derived from the particularity of the churches,*" but are nevertheless

interior to each particular Church. Consequently, “*we must see the ministry of the Successor of Peter, not only as a ‘global’ service, reaching each particular church from ‘outside,’ as it were, but as belonging already to the essence of each particular church from ‘within.’*” Indeed, the ministry of the primacy involves, in essence, a truly episcopal power, which is not only supreme, full, and universal, but also *immediate*, over everybody, whether pastors or other faithful. The ministry of the Successor of Peter as something *interior* to each particular church is a necessary expression of that fundamental *mutual interiority* between universal Church and particular church.¹⁶

The visible unity for which Jesus prayed, “so that the world can believe that thou has sent me” (John 17:21), is made easily identifiable by Christ: it must be a religious society that Jesus established two thousand years ago, not one thousand or five hundred, and it also must have existed *perpetually*, because, as Jesus says, “the gates of hell would not prevail against it” (Matt 16:18). Only the Catholic Church, founded by Our Lord on St. Peter and his papal successors, qualifies.

In addition, the Church’s visible unity must be as indivisible in character as the oneness of the Father and the Son, as Jesus says (John 17:22–23), a oneness necessarily shared in also by the Holy Spirit who, as the eternal Spirit of the Father and the Son, would be “sent” at Pentecost to indwell the infant apostolic Church. Brought into vital and indissoluble union with the Three in One, the Church cannot be sundered. Despite its historical vicissitudes that will sometimes see large numbers separated from its unity, the Church itself remains always undivided, as St. Cyprian would testify in the third century: “There is one God, and one Christ, and His Church is one, and the Faith one, and His people one, joined

¹⁶ Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Letter to the Bishops of the Catholic Church on Some Aspects of the Church Understood as Communion* (May 28, 1992), no. 13, emphasis original.

into the solid unity of one body. Unity cannot be rent asunder, nor the one body be separated through the division of its structure."¹⁷

If the hierarchical structure of the Church, namely, its bishops in the apostolic succession, images the indivisible oneness of the Trinity, which Eastern Orthodox theologians are seen to affirm, Euthymios, this can only be, as I've emphasized, because the episcopate of the Church necessarily contains an indefectible visible headship and center of unity, whose exercise of supreme authority by Peter's successors maintains the Church as one distinctive body and, indeed, the Mystical Body of Christ. A mere union of patriarchs and bishops who teach a common faith is not sufficient to establish an indivisible unity in the Church (i.e., one that would mirror the indivisible unity of the Trinity).

Here again, the denial of the *Filioque* is shown to be crucial, because, in effect, the denial separates the Spirit from His eternal origin in the Son, and thereby introduces schism into the inner life of the Blessed Trinity. The division within the Godhead, in turn, results in the visible disunity of the Church, the icon of the Trinity as centered on the divinely established Rock of Peter. The Byzantine Greco-Slav Schism has been justified by Orthodox Christians in the interest of preserving the *monarchia* of God the Father in the Blessed Trinity. However, its formal denial of the Son's active participation in the procession of the Holy Spirit has only resulted in the Spirit being alien to the Son, thus destroying, as it were,¹⁸ the direct union of the Holy Spirit with the Son from whom He eternally proceeds. There consequently occurs an unwarranted subordination of Christology to pneumatology (i.e., the Son is rendered subordinate to the Holy Spirit in Christ's arrangement for the hierarchical structure ruling the Church).¹⁹

¹⁷ St. Cyprian, *De Catholicae Ecclesiae Unitate*, ch. 23. See also Eph 4:4–6.

¹⁸ Because it's impossible for such destruction to actually take place within the Triune Godhead.

¹⁹ Or, as it were, at least disunity between the Son and the Holy Spirit, which has translated into divisive competition in the visible Church, because some Christians invoke the guidance of the Holy Spirit against the supreme Petrine office, which Jesus established as a bulwark against disunity.

Denial of the *Filioque* among the Eastern Orthodox opened the door for excessive spiritualization of the Church, wherein they fatally obscured the office of the Petrine ministry of the Roman Pontiff as visible head of Christ's visible Church. Instead of the Pope as chief pastor of the Church and jurisdictional bearer of the supreme power of the keys, we have the Spirit of God dwelling in sixteen autocephalous churches, whose bishops are acclaimed to be "equals in authority," but who find their authority subject to a vague "consensus" of "the whole Church," which consequently fosters further disunity. This excessive spiritualization of the earthly Church may appear to be in line with the Eastern Fathers' emphasis on the divine side of the Church, but it seriously neglects the human side of the theandric Church, whose Divine Founder provided a visible head for a visible Church to perpetuate Christ's visible humanity in time.

It should become increasingly evident to you, Euthymios, that a rejection of the doctrine of the *Filioque* results in a doctrine of the Holy Spirit (pneumatology) that has been freed from its Christological grounding, thereby fostering an anti-hierarchical and anti-authority bias that fosters disunity, in grave contrast to what Our Lord prayed for so earnestly (John 17:20–23). Indeed, eventually this Trinitarian displacement would lead to disobedience to "the head of all the churches of God," and then formal schism from the Petrine center of Catholic unity. As history testifies, we now witness the extent of the serious crippling of the apostolic ministry and canonical order among the Byzantine Greco-Slav autocephalous churches.

Scholars studying the origins of the Hesychastic controversy of the fourteenth century may be said to throw needed light on the manner in which an excessive spiritualization of the Church can be traced to the mystical teaching of the visionary Symeon the New Theologian (949–1022) and that of his biographer Nicetas Stethatos. Their writings, as well as those of such thirteenth-century spiritual authors as Gregory of Sinai and Nicephorus the monk, manifest the development of a dangerous

ecclesiological mysticism among the Byzantines, wherein the visible and authoritative hierarchical structure of the Church begins to be overshadowed by an appeal to direct personal experience of the Holy Spirit, which can take root when conflicts occur between lay, priestly, episcopal, and papal leaders. The primacy of spiritual experience, on the part of those allegedly gifted with extraordinary charisms, has proceeded to replace the divinely established primacy of authority in matters of doctrine, and sadly prefigured the religious subjectivism that is fundamental to, and which has exploded within, Protestantism. For example, personal experience of the Holy Spirit began to be held in some monastic circles as a precondition for the exercise of spiritual authority. Symeon the New Theologian had caused some wonderment among his contemporaries when he claimed that the non-ordained (i.e., those who were “Spirit-filled”) could hear the confessions of the faithful and give them absolution. Though he did not go so far as to declare the invalidity of the sacraments conferred by worldly and corrupt priests and bishops, he clearly insinuated that only those who personally experience the charisms of the Holy Spirit and similar divine activity are the genuine teachers and theologians of the Church. And, significantly, his biographer Nicetas Stethatos was a supporter of the Patriarch Michael Cerularius in the latter’s eleventh-century attacks on Latin liturgical customs; and Stethatos himself would write *Synthesis against the Latins*, in which he said Catholics “blaspheme the Holy Spirit [by] saying He proceeded from the Son.”

Further, Symeon the New Theologian’s accentuation of the charismatic element in the Church, coupled with disparaging remarks on the office of bishop, could only lead to a denial of the Church’s hierarchical structure and therefore the God-established means for fostering and maintaining order and unity. These latent challenges to the Church as a hierarchical authority and institution, by an emphasis on the “spiritual authority” of “Spirit-filled monks,” would receive, as I noted earlier in Letter Fifty, its monastic flowering with the ascetical and mystical teaching of Gregory Palamas

(1296–1359), whose followers would dominate the Byzantine ecclesiastical establishment in the fourteenth century.

In Abbot Joachim of Fiore (d. 1202), who hailed from Calabria, Italy—then under Byzantine rule and influence—one finds a similarly excessive spiritualization of the Church, and this also very much dependent upon an error involving the procession of the Holy Spirit. Fiore's teaching resulted in a resounding condemnation by the Fourth Lateran Ecumenical Council (1215). In reply to Abbot Joachim's exaggeration of the distinction between the three Divine Persons, the Council insisted:

In orthodox Catholic faith we believe them [the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit] of one substance. . . . It is therefore clear that the Son, in being begotten, received the substance of the Father without any diminution, and thus Father and Son have the same substance. Thus, the Father, and the Son, and the Holy Spirit who proceeds from both are the same reality.²⁰

The aberrations of the anti-papal Franciscan rebels (i.e., the *Spirituali*²¹ of the fourteenth century), were influenced by Joachim of Fiore's apocalyptic theology about a "Third Age of the Holy Spirit," which dealt largely with issues foreign to the Byzantine scene, such as an alleged requirement that friars practice "absolute poverty." But what is curiously similar among both Franciscan *Spirituali* and Palamite Hesychasts is the claim to comprise a spiritual elite, made up of those especially illuminated and enlightened by the Holy Spirit, and who thereby possess an experience not given to worldly and corrupt hierarchs. Maintaining that tragic divorce of pneumatology from Christology would become traditional among the Byzantine supporters of Photius's anti-*Filioque* doctrine. Boasting of visionary experiences of the "uncreated

²⁰ Fourth Lateran Council (1215), *Acts of the Council*, canon 2, "On the Error of Abbot Joachim."

²¹ Also known as the Fraticelli.

energies of God,” the anti-*Filioque* Palamites heralded a new spiritual world order of love amidst the coming collapse of the Byzantine Empire, and they saw themselves as superior to the prelates (and other monks), who criticized their theological innovations. It was this monastic elite who would regard themselves as the preservers of orthodoxy and the true leaders of the established Byzantine Church. Their ecclesiological mysticism would lead to the mantra recited by all too many modern Eastern Orthodox writers: The Church, that is the life in the Holy Spirit, does not know any authority or power, except the “power of love.” This view subverts the infallible hierarchical authority that Jesus established to maintain the visible unity of His Church. This misguided mysticism cannot be reconciled with the view of ecclesiastical power that the Church held during the first millennium, much less with Eastern Orthodoxy’s own major confessions of faith (e.g., Peter Mohila’s 1640 *Orthodox Confession of Faith* or the 1672 *Confession of Dositheos*).

This unfortunate diminishing of the visible Church and its hierarchical authority, in favor of a “Church of the Spirit,” was stigmatized by the great Russian philosopher Vladimir Soloviev as “ecclesiological Apollinarianism” (i.e., ignoring the human dimension of the Church represented by its hierarchy of Pope and bishops, and accentuating its divine elements). As I originally noted in *Ending the Byzantine Greek Schism*, the unbalanced pneumatology that influences modern Eastern Orthodox theologians has led to the Spirit of Christ being placed in false opposition to the visible juridical-social structure of the Church, which, again, *Jesus Himself instituted*. Our separated brethren forget that there can be no real conflict between the invisible mission of the Holy Spirit, the Spirit of truth, sent by Christ to “teach the apostles all the truth” (see John 16:13), and the visible mission of the papacy commissioned by *the same Jesus Christ* to teach, govern, and sanctify all His lambs and sheep (see John 21:15–17). It is through the hierarchical Magisterium of the Church (i.e., the bishops in union with the supreme visible teacher within the body of Christ, the

Successor of Peter) that the Church is seen to be a theandric body that does full justice to both its divine and human aspects. The divine aspect of the Church is manifested in the Risen Christ, invisible head of the Church, who sustains the Church by His Holy Spirit, who, in turn, works everything supernatural among the members of the Church. The sacred humanity of the Incarnate Word is similarly rendered visible to men by the sacred hierarchical structure of the Church, through which Jesus, as the invisible and theandric head of the Church, continues to teach, govern, and sanctify all those whom He has redeemed on the Cross (see Matt 28:18–20; Luke 10:16). In that hierarchical and social structure of the Church, the Successor of Peter possesses the fullness of ecclesiastical power that Catholic Tradition has always seen to have been confided to Peter, chief and head of the apostles (see Matt 16:18–19; Luke 22:31–32). It is through the Roman Pontiff, as the preeminent Vicar of Christ on earth and its chief hierarchy, especially assisted by Christ's own Spirit, that the Lord Jesus Christ, as divine head of the Church Militant, exercises His theandric teaching actions. If, as many Eastern Orthodox continue to believe, Christ is the head of a divine-human visible organism, its perfect integrity as a divine and human society demands a visible hierarchical head. Denial of the papacy only results in a radical mutilation and disfigurement of the Church.

Allow me, Euthymios, to sum up Catholic teaching concerning the Church as the icon of the Trinity. The Church reflects on earth God's unity in Trinity. That unity is indivisible. As the Son and the Holy Spirit have but one principle, which is the Father, so also the universal Church, one and Catholic, can have but one visible head, who serves as the center of unity and wields the keys of final authority. The Church, as a visible, hierarchical, and collegial communion, requires precisely that indivisible hierarchical center if it is to truly reflect the indivisible unity of the Trinity. The Church as icon of the Trinity, therefore, is to be found only among the plurality of bishops of the Catholic Church gathered about their apostolic head and center of unity, the Bishop of Rome, who

succeeds to the primacy of St. Peter in the Church. All Church history witnesses to the essentially Christocentric nature of the primacy of Peter. For it is that perpetual primacy, instituted by Jesus Christ, which keeps the collegial episcopate one and undivided in its mission to “teach all nations” all that He, the Lord, had commanded them (see Matt 28:18–20).

I conclude, Euthymios, with this quotation from the great work on the Trinity by Fr. Bertrand de Margerie, who has beautifully (and appropriately) written:

It is conjointly by the *Filioque*, and by the recognition of the primacy of service and love of the Vicar of Christ, that the Holy Spirit wishes to glorify the Son from whom He proceeds and who is the head of the Church of which He is the soul.²²

²² Fr. de Margerie, *The Christian Trinity in History*, 176.